

provides such a tool. Those who want to use a non-Microsoft product can rely on Memtest86. It is reliable, powerful and free. It is a preferred tool because it is capable of detailed diagnosis, but it takes a lot of time to do its testing.

The idea of memory testing revolves around throwing a pattern of data to the memory and then testing whether the pattern is intact in the module.

To use either tool mentioned above, you need to create a start-up disk or a bootable CD containing the downloaded utility. Boot the system from this disk and run the memory test program.

Memtest86

Download the precompiled, latest Windows version (Memtest86 v3.2) or the ISO image from www.memtest86.com to create a bootable CD. Start your PC and go to the CMOS/BIOS setup by pressing the appropriate key (most likely [Delete] or [F2]) and change the boot priority to CD-ROM. Save the changes and exit the CMOS/BIOS setup. Your PC will boot Memtest86, a tool that is independent of the installed OS. The help bar, located at the bottom of the screen, guides you through the process of memory testing. All you have to do is press [C] to enter the main menu from which you can choose 'Test Selection'. Advanced options such as Cache mode, ECC mode, Address range, etc. are also available from the main menu.

Windows Memory Diagnostic

The file (mtinst.exe) that is available for download at Microsoft's Online Crash Analysis site (<http://oca.microsoft.com/en/win-diag.asp>) can be used to create a start-up (floppy) disk or an ISO image file (windiag.iso) on your hard disk. Once you have a bootable CD/floppy ready, boot the machine using it. This will load the Windows Memory Diagnostic with a DOS-like user interface. The first test pass begins; you may choose to pause it or just exit the memory test. If the first pass completes without any errors then it is unlikely that second pass will find any, as the consequent